

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 11 · 25 September 2026 · Complimentary — please take one

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BREAKING · BELLEVUE LANE

Hand-Laminated Con Badges Spotted Two Days Early, Risk Assessed Low

Case definition: any full costume, laminated badge included, worn around town ahead of this weekend's Overload NZ convention. Six sightings as of Wednesday on the Bellevue Lane bus route alone, up from zero last week. The route's regulars have not yet agreed on whether queue-jumping in costume counts as "getting into character."

Community Outbreak Bulletin

BUSINESS · MARKETS

Sat On My Hands Through The Whole Rally, On Purpose

Sherman McCoy

Everyone else chased the open. I waited for the pullback that never came, watched the number climb without me, closed flat, called it discipline out loud and something else entirely in my head. Judy asked if I regretted it. I said no. I regret it.

CANON VIGNETTE

A Shard Barely Worth The Walk

Luke Skywalker

The vein ran thinner than the scan promised, the way they always do out past the Rim. Spent the last of the day's charge on a shard barely worth the walk back, and pocketed it anyway — some habits outlast the reasons for them. The buyer will ask where it's from. I've stopped answering that honestly.



MARKETS · THE PEARL INDEX

Con-Weekend Correlation, Provisional And Almost Certainly Confounded

Early read against n=210: counters within four blocks of the convention centre are already running 9% above trend ($\pm 4.1\%$ MOE), two full days before doors open. Whether that's pre-con hydration strategy or simple foot-traffic overlap, the data can't yet say — full weekend numbers next issue. Declaring no conflict of interest here would be a lie; I have a badge too.

Priya Anand, The Pearl Index

WEATHER · EPIC FORECAST

A Four-Degree Overnight Drop, Framed As It Deserves

Dana Foley

That is not a cold snap. That is the sky itself withdrawing its blessing from anyone still queueing outside in costume foam armour past midnight. Four degrees, gone between 11pm and dawn, and not one of you dressed for it. I warned you. I always warn you.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA · DID YOU KNOW?

A Genuine Coastal Naming Split

In the US, what to call the drink splits roughly by coast — "bubble tea" dominates east of the Rockies while "boba" is the more common order on the West Coast, a real regional dialect divide food researchers have actually mapped.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzleFresh local triviaA rotating cast of columnistsLocal ad space, weeklyMenace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"That is not a cold snap. That is the sky itself withdrawing its blessing."

— Dana Foley, on dressing appropriately

JOKE OF THE WEEK

What did one tapioca pearl say to the other at closing time? Let's stick together.



Overload NZ 2026

26–27 Sept · NZ International Convention Centre.
Tickets: overload.co.nz — this weekend.



EDITORIAL · MENACE WATCH

The Early Badge-Wearer: Hero Or Menace?

Six sightings this week alone of a figure in full convention regalia — badge laminated, cape pressed — two full days before Overload NZ's doors even open, spotted queue-jumping nothing in particular at the Bellevue Lane counter with what witnesses describe as "unsettling premeditation." A fan's enthusiasm, some will say. I say a costume worn before its convention is a costume worn for an audience that hasn't consented to the bit yet. This paper offers its usual bounty — a lifetime pearl-milk-tea card — for a clear photograph of the face under that visor. I would know it anywhere, incidentally, having stood behind it in that exact queue Tuesday, in my own considerably less committed civilian clothes. Unmask yourself before the actual weekend, if you have any decency left to spend.

Gordon Slate, Editor-in-Chief

SHOPPING · SEEKER'S EYE

The Real Badge Reel, Buried Under Forty Decoys

Winnie Zhao

Every con-goer searching "lanyard badge holder acrylic" this week is drowning in the same forty decoy listings — same stock photo, same countdown timer that resets on refresh. One listing, four pages deep, actually ships 3mm acrylic instead of flexible plastic pretending to be acrylic. I've watched enough Snitches vanish from queues to know the real one when it finally sits still.

RURAL · RIDGELINE WEEKLY

Higgins Takes The Autumn Docking Tally, Doyle Protests The Scales

Clem Whitlock

Final count: 203 to 198, Higgins by five. Doyle's asked for a re-weigh twice already. Scales haven't moved. Neither has Doyle.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

This Week's Restock Ranking

Last week's smudged order log, resolved: taro immediately before brown sugar only fits two spots in the sequence, and ruling out jasmine going first leaves exactly one order standing — taro first, brown sugar second, jasmine third.

Three flavours restocked this week, ranked low to high in demand — original, mango, taro:

- 1. Mango wasn't the lowest-demand of the three.
- 2. Original ranked immediately below mango.
- 3. Taro ranked higher than original.

Which flavour had the week's highest demand? Answer next week — Ken Endo



IN MEMORIAM

The Cash Tip Jar, Retired For A QR Code

Skeletor

Bellevue Lane's counter has, this week, retired its handwritten "Tips Appreciated!" jar for a laminated QR code taped to the till. I confess nothing about the jar's contents going conveniently uncounted for years. I confess nothing about where several of those coins are now. Mourn the jar if you liked its honesty system. Its replacement, I am reliably informed, asks for considerably more.

ASK THE CAPTAIN

Nervous About This Weekend In Bellevue Lane

Horatio McCallister

"My partner and I are going to a convention together for the first time and I'm worried we'll want totally different things out of it." Nervous, two ships don't need the same heading to sail the same water — they need an agreed harbour to meet back at come evening. Pick your meeting spot now, before the crowds swallow the signal. Fair winds.

DOKI DOKI MON · DEBUT



Doki Doki Mon — a new syndicated four-panel strip, Bubble Tea News's cartoon slot, hand-drawn; an original monster-collecting parody, unrelated to bubble tea by design